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Building parent-child connectedness through arts, storytelling, and multi-sensory experiences: An asset for preventing family violence

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ABSTRACT

The COVID-19 pandemic created a climate of instability that has weakened the most vulnerable populations, including immigrant families living in the Parc-Extension neighbourhood of Montréal. Exacerbated by other risks facing immigrant families, such as single parenthood, social isolation, economic insecurity, and limited access to support services, the stress caused by this unusual situation may have contributed to an increase in family violence. To address the risk of deteriorating mental health among parents and foster healthy relationships within families in the neighbourhood, Parc-Extension Youth Organization (PEYO) developed a home-based community art therapy program, *Art et Contes en famille,* as part of a research-intervention. This preventive program is based on the power of expressive therapies to ease anxiety, strengthen family connectedness and foster coping skills and resilience as protective factors for family violence. This article aims to present a multiple-case study focusing on two families from different ethnic backgrounds who participated in *Art et Contes en famille*. More specifically, drawing on creative arts therapists' observation notes and the creations produced by family members, it will illustrate how their participation enabled them to strengthen parent-child connectedness through better connection, autonomy, and regulation.

Family violence is a multi-level phenomenon that cannot be reduced to a single risk factor or cause (Austin et al., 2020). As studies have shown, the risk of violence and neglect increases when families experience multiple risk factors simultaneously (Vial et al., 2020), a situation that may have been exacerbated by the COVID-19 pandemic (Humphreys et al., 2020). These factors include socio-economic status, criminal behaviour, difficult childhood experiences, family conflict, low family cohesion and the presence of domestic violence (Stith et al., 2009). Newly arrived families, particularly single-parent families, often face multiple challenges specific to their situation that can increase parental stress and create an environment conducive to the emergence of family violence (Atwell et al., 2009; Patwardhan et al., 2017). Among these factors, we find financial difficulties, precarious work conditions, and lack of affordable housing. Language barriers, racism and discrimination can also increase individual vulnerability (Atwell et al., 2009). Nevertheless, these families also possess strengths that can be leveraged to reinforce protective factors and thereby prevent family violence, through creative arts therapies, for example.

Creative arts therapies could indeed be beneficial to reduce risk factors and increase protective factors associated with the development of family violence within migrant families. Arts activities with newcomers help manage stress, reduce anxiety, relieve post-traumatic stress symptoms, while also fostering hope (Oepen & Gruber, 2024). More specifically, a systematic review by Martin et al. (2018) concluded that over 80% of the empirical studies analyzed reported positive effects of the creative arts therapies or arts interventions for stress reduction or management. The contribution of integrated arts therapies to the alleviation of anxiety symptoms and the improvement of relationship quality has also been noted (Bokoch et al., 2025). Finally, art therapy and expressive therapies offer promising avenues for intervention to

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strengthen parent-child connectedness (Bat Or et al., 2019), which is considered a "super-protector" (Lezin et al., 2004, p. 1).

Considering the above, we conducted a study to assess how the *Art et Contes en famille* program, implemented by the Parc-Extension Youth Organization (PEYO), might positively impact connectedness within immigrant families, given that this could help prevent the risk of family violence by reducing parental stress. The program being preventive, PEYO selected families facing multiple challenges for intervention. More specifically, this article focuses on the case studies of two single-mother families whose circumstances made them vulnerable to heightened parental stress and mental health issues, as it will be discussed below. Analysis of the creative arts therapists' observation notes and the family members' artworks suggested that parent-child co-creation may have helped strengthen connection, autonomy, and regulation between parents and children, thereby fostering a better parent-child connectedness, a factor likely to act as a safeguard against the onset of family violence (Ayika et al., 2018).

Family violence and its impact on families

According to the Canadian Department of Justice (2024), family violence is defined as various violent acts committed by one family member against another, involving a single incident or a pattern of recurring actions. These violent acts can take the form of abuse and can manifest themselves in a variety of ways, including physical, emotional, psychological, or sexual harm. These acts are considered violence when there is an intent to control, dominate, or exert power over family members (Comité permanent de la condition féminine, 2022). Family violence can also take the form of neglect, that is the failure to provide or absence of appropriate care (whether physical or medical care, adequate parental supervision, or educational support) necessary to ensure the child's emotional safety and well-being (Austin et al., 2020; Liel et al., 2022). Neglect often manifests itself through parental indifference and absence (Harden, 2014).

Experiencing or witnessing family violence has an impact on family members' mental health that varies depending on its severity, duration, and its form (Liel et al., 2022). Exposure to violence has serious consequences on children's cognitive, social, and emotional development (Austin et al., 2020). Additionally, exposure to excessive stress has significant repercussions on the nervous system, which may become over or under-responsive to stress (Harden, 2014). Potential impacts on children also include depressive symptoms, difficulty engaging in pleasurable activities (e.g., play), hypervigilance, sleep disorders, difficulty regulating emotions and learning difficulties (Austin et al., 2020). They are generally prone to aggressive and impulsive behaviours and can even engage in violent behaviours themselves (Arai et al., 2021). These repercussions are long-lasting and can persist into adulthood, notably through the onset of depressive symptoms as well as difficulties in maintaining healthy relationships and resolving conflicts (Liel et al., 2022).

Research has shown that single parenthood can be a risk factor for the development of family violence (Parashak, 2011; Stith et al., 2009). Although single parents do not necessarily develop violent, abusive, or neglectful behaviours, they may be more likely to live in precarious socio-economic conditions that can significantly affect their stress levels and their emotional availability in their parenting role (Lezin et al., 2004). Given the convergence of multiple simultaneous challenges, some families may be at greater risk of family violence than others (Vial et al., 2020) – as can be the case for some, though not all, migrant families.

Migration and risk of family violence

Migration has a significant impact on family dynamics and is one risk factor for family violence (Ayika et al., 2018; Timshel et al., 2017). From the pre-migration phase through resettlement, the journeys of many migrant families are marked by complex losses and potentially traumatic events. These include risks of human trafficking, traumatic loss, and physical, sexual, or psychological abuse (Priebe et al., 2016). Pre-migration risk factors are often exacerbated by resettlement-related stressors, such as struggles with social integration and isolation, which are themselves heightened by discrimination and prejudice in the host country (Ayika et al., 2018). Other factors such as family separation, language barriers, employment difficulty, housing uncertainty, and lengthy legal procedures, can also have a negative impact on families (Atwell et al., 2009). Prolonged exposure to stress can increase vulnerability to psychological distress, notably by raising the risk of post-traumatic stress disorder and major depression (Turner & Lloyd, 1995). This cumulative adversity can then turn into a "chronic process of traumatization" and have long-lasting effects (De Haene et al., 2010).

Research has shown that trauma can significantly impact parent-child connectedness (Timshel et al., 2017; van Ee et al., 2012). From an attachment theoretical framework, the intergenerational transmission of parental trauma suggests that trauma can disrupt attachment representations in both the parent and the child (Timshel et al., 2017). These internal cognitive-affective representations of the self in relation to others serve to attune and regulate attachment-related affects, behaviours, and responses (Bacro et al., 2020). Furthermore, when a parent is unable to regulate their own emotions due to post-traumatic symptoms, a role reversal regarding caregiving responsibilities may sometimes occur (De Haene et al., 2010).

Parent-child connectedness as protective factor

Family resources can decrease the risks of family violence and improve capacities for adjustment and resilience (Martinez-Torteya et al., 2009). The quality of family bonds and the family environment is considered one of the most important protective factors, particularly in a migration context where the family often plays a central role (Ayika et al., 2018). Research has shown that family-based prevention programs focusing on strengthening family relationships, especially parent-child connectedness can promote positive outcomes for children (Ryzin & Fosco, 2015). It is well established that a warm and positive parent-child relationship acts as a protective factor (Martinez-Torteya et al., 2009), whereas a poor parent-child relationship has been shown to increase the risk of family violence and its impact on children's development and mental health (Liel et al., 2022; Stith et al., 2009; Timshel et al., 2017). It is often within the parent-child relationship that children first develop their sense of self in relation to others, their understanding of the world, and essential skills for regulation and social interaction (Bacro et al., 2020).

Parent-child connectedness also constitutes a key protective factor in child development. It is defined as a mutual sense of emotional connection, trust, respect, understanding, and support between parent and child (Lezin et al., 2004). Parents contribute to connectedness by creating a safe and predictable environment, providing structure and guidance, expressing affection, and dedicating quality time to shared activities (Hordyk et al., 2015). While attachment theory focuses primarily on the caregiver's impact on development, specifically the mother's availability and responsiveness to the child (Barber & Schluterman, 2008; Clark & Ladd, 2000), parent-child connectedness highlights the dynamic and reciprocal nature of this relationship, wherein both parent and child are active participants (Barber & Schluterman, 2008; Lezin et al., 2004). Connectedness has indeed been described as an active involvement in emotional exchanges with others with reciprocity – mutual give and take – being one of its defining characteristics (Barber & Schluterman, 2008).

Play is a concrete way to foster a healthy parent-child relationship. Sensory, rhythmic, or dramatic play supports secure attachment and contributes to cognitive and emotional development, while storytelling facilitates memory organization and emotional processing (Jennings, 2010). Moreover, joint or parallel creation has demonstrated several

benefits for strengthening family cohesion and parent-child connectedness (Bat Or et al., 2019; Parashak, 2011). Family art therapy enables the child and the caregiver to connect in an environment that fosters respect and emotional security (Nieduziak, 2021). It also bridges the child's play-centred non-verbal language with the parent's verbal communication (Gavron & Mayseless, 2018).

Theoretical framework

Parent-child connectedness encompasses eight components – attachment/bonding, warmth/caring, cohesion, support/involvement, communication, monitoring/control, autonomy granting, and maternal/paternal characteristics – which collectively promote security and supportiveness (Lezin et al., 2004). As will be shown below, these components play a role in the development of **connection, autonomy, and regulation**. Together, they form the foundation of a strong, balanced, and developmentally supportive parent-child relationship.

Connection

Connection describes a relationship in which both parent and child influence each other, shaping a high-quality relationship through emotional exchange (Lezin et al., 2004). A high-quality relationship is characterized by a desire to spend time together. The parent makes themselves available, dedicates quality time, and recognizes the child's value (Clark & Ladd, 2000). Shared experiences and moments of closeness become collective memories, fostering a sense of family belonging and strengthening familial bonds (Lezin et al., 2004).

Meaningful experiences of moments of play and creative activities within the family, imbued with pleasure and fun, promote a sense of security in children and help build a warm and mutually understanding family environment (Arrington, 2001; Parashak, 2011). Collaborative activities also allow family members to work together toward a common goal, such as creating a collective artwork, which fosters a sense of belonging and recognizes individual strengths within the family (Gavron & Mayseless, 2018). Family creative activities further develop communication skills and the ability to express emotions, thus offering a new vision of the family dynamics (Arrington, 2001; Nieduziak, 2021). Through negotiation and sharing, each member can express their perspective and restore harmony within the family (Nieduziak, 2021).

Autonomy

While connection fosters a sense of belonging within the family, it is equally important to consider how autonomy enables the individual to define themselves as a distinct person within that family. Described as one of the "fundamental *needs* of development" (Barber & Schluterman, 2008), autonomy is the capacity to express oneself freely and act according to one's own will and identity within the family (Barber & Schluterman, 2008; Lezin et al., 2004). Supporting the autonomy of a child involves recognizing their right to make choices while building their moral and emotional development (Miller, 2023). Although autonomy is often presented from the child's perspective, parents also have a right to their own autonomy within the family. Finding a balance between relationships that are overly enmeshed or too distant helps ensure a healthy level of autonomy for all family members and is crucial for healthy parent-child relationships (Harden, 2014).

Using artistic media facilitates the encounter between the caregiver and the child by employing new modes of communication that offer greater individual freedom (Parashak, 2011). During creative moments, parents and children can create side by side, giving them the opportunity to make both individual and collective decisions (Ryzin & Fosco, 2015). Artworks reflect the creator's inner world and sharing them with family members allows emotions to be expressed, shared, seen and heard in a new and softer way (Arrington, 2001). Art may also help define and respect individual boundaries, thereby fostering a sense of psychological autonomy. Therefore, the creation of artistic representations of family members makes it possible to establish tangible, concrete distinctions between them and reinforces their uniqueness within the family (Bat Or, 2010; Gavron & Mayseless, 2018).

Regulation

The ability to regulate one's emotions is an important parenting skill for establishing and maintaining strong parent-child connectedness. Regulation is viewed as a set of actions undertaken by parents to structure their child's behaviours in order to support their growth and ensure their physical and emotional safety. This includes aspects such as establishing age-appropriate rules, supervising and monitoring children, as well as helping them regulate their emotions (Lezin et al., 2004). Accordingly, parents must be able to structure their own environment and to self-regulate. The parent's regulation difficulties will inevitably have a direct impact on the child's behaviour and on their ability to contain their emotions and evolve in their environment (Lanjekar et al., 2022).

With the aim of regulating the environment in which the child develops, the art therapy session provides a containing space that can enable the parent to establish a safe framework for exploring various possibilities and setting boundaries (Proulx, 2002). Moreover, art therapy highlights the possibilities for co-regulation and acceptance of the other within the relationship (Bat Or et al., 2019). Co-regulation can occur during the creative process, as the child actively participates at the same level as the parent, which can support the parent's regulation. In doing so, a reciprocal dynamic emerges, through which the child and the parent develop their regulatory capacities (Gavron & Mayseless, 2018). Co-regulation within the artistic process can reveal repressed or unconscious content, such as traumatic memories, fears, or anxieties, which can then be processed (Arrington, 2001). This can mitigate their often-negative impact on family relationships.

Methods

This article presents case studies based on qualitative data collected as part of a mixed-methods intervention study that also included creative approaches. The primary research objectives were to explore the effects of the *Art et Contes en famille* program on (1) reducing parent anxiety and (2) enhancing family dynamics among immigrant, refugee, and asylum-seeking families in a neighbourhood with a high proportion of immigrant residents in Montréal (Canada). We developed the program to support migrant families in the neighbourhood following the COVID-19 pandemic and, consequently, the intervention aimed to reduce risk factors associated with the development of family violence, while working to strengthen protective factors. Accordingly, selected families did not have to experience family violence to participate in the research. In total, 73 families from the area participated in the intervention, of which 18 were invited to participate in the research and gave their consent. Due to different cultural ways of defining and experiencing family, extended family members were sometimes involved in the sessions, and most of the participating children were school-aged (6–12 years old). The intervention began in the fall of 2022, when most of the health measures were lifted, but the repercussions of the pandemic on the most vulnerable families continued to be felt. The study received approval from the research ethics committee of the Université du Québec en Abitibi-Témiscamingue (UQAT), with which the principal investigator is affiliated.

Intervention: Art et Contes en famille

Creative arts therapists with a master's degree facilitated eight to ten two-hour workshops based on an expressive arts therapies approach focusing on the expressiveness of the individual by varying the creative modalities. This was made possible thanks to the composition of the

team, which included different creative arts therapists who were able to combine their specializations. The workshops took place either in groups of several families at the Parc-Extension Youth Organization's premises, or at home with a single family, allowing for greater accessibility to the intervention. Home-based workshops were led by one creative arts therapist, while groups of several families were facilitated by two or more creative arts therapists, depending on the number of participating families present. The workshops had the following structure:

- **Opening ritual:** Workshop facilitators led an ice-breaking activity, often through music (e.g., xylophone, egg shakers, bells, drums, synthesizer, voice) or body expression, to explore how family members were feeling.
- **Storytelling:** Workshop facilitators then told a story in an interactive way, inviting family members to participate by responding to questions or playing a role in the story. The stories were chosen to meet the needs of each participating family and to address themes that might symbolically resonate with their experiences.
- **Creative expression:** Creative arts therapists provided different artistic media such as pastels, paints, playdough, and other craft materials, and invited participants to create an artwork of their choice, either individually or together.
- **Sharing:** Each participant presented their work to the other people and had the opportunity to talk about their experience of the workshop process.
- **Closing ritual**: To symbolically close the creative space, and ensure emotional regulation, workshop facilitators invited family members to name an element of the workshop that they wished to keep, transform or leave behind.

The specific details of each workshop activity were chosen by the creative arts therapists based on the current needs of each family. During the workshops, the creative arts therapists maintained the therapeutic framework and established a climate of trust to support families in their creative process. As such, they did not offer interpretations to family members but helped them establish a dialogue and a relationship with their creations, while remaining attentive and supportive witnesses of their creative process as is recommended by Moon (2016).

Qualitative data collection

Research assistants collected qualitative and quantitative data from the 18 participating families. To gain an in-depth understanding of the effects of the *Art et Contes en famille* program on family dynamics and parental stress, this article focused exclusively on the qualitative data to build a multiple case study, comprising two cases, aimed at addressing the research question regarding family dynamics (Yin, 2017). Data collection relied heavily on arts-based data collection tools. These enable access to individuals' in-depth understanding of their own experiences, through an examination of the artistic process and artwork itself, while providing valid research data (Leavy, 2018). Namely, drawings and art creations have been used with children and adults in a research context to examine their perceptions of their relationships (Gernhardt et al., 2016; Regev & Patishi, 2017).

Research assistants invited family members to complete a pre- and post-intervention assessment based on the *Kinetic Family Drawing* (KFD). It consists of drawing your family involved in an activity and the assessment is valuable for revealing family dynamics by depicting how individuals perceive their family roles and relationships (Burns & Kaufman, 1970; Wegmann & Lusebrink, 2000). The creative arts therapists who facilitated the workshops also recorded their observations after each session in a template (e.g., context, engagement and behaviours of each family member, or participants' comments on their creations). The notes also included information about the activities the participants engaged in. Workshop facilitators also took care to photograph the artworks created by each family member to analyze them later. The facilitators' observation notes and the participants' artworks were the primary sources of data on which the case studies are based, although KFDs were also coded during the analysis.

Qualitative data analysis

The research team analyzed the qualitative data following a deductive process that built on existing knowledge about parental anxiety and family dynamics. The thematic analysis process was also inductive in the sense that the team remained open to the emergence of new knowledge (Naeem et al., 2023). First, two research assistants (a dramatherapist and a master's student in art therapy) independently coded the observation notes of the workshop facilitators and the images of artwork created by the participants (*Kinetic Family Drawings* and artworks done during the workshops). Doing so, they kept in mind the research objectives and paid particular attention to content relating to parental anxiety and family dynamics, such as behaviours, attitudes, symbols and metaphors used in connection with the expression of emotions, relationships (between real or abstract people or characters), group dynamics (e.g., respect or lack thereof, sharing, support, listening). The research assistants then compared their analyses to refine the themes and identify the two families discussed in this article. These families were representative for addressing the research question regarding family dynamics, while also shedding light on the experiences of single-parent families in this regard. This comparison process also allowed them to identify any discrepancies between their analyses and to return to the raw data to resolve them. A further, more in-depth reading of the data from these two cases brought to light new themes related to connection, autonomy, and regulation, which were then subjected to a new, more deductive analysis (Guest et al., 2012). A final analysis was conducted by the principal investigator to cross-check the interpretation and increase trustworthiness (Nowell et al., 2017), which also enabled a comprehensive understanding of the dynamics of the two families. Given that the participating families did not cross-check the analysis, the presentation of the case studies and their subsequent interpretation stem from choices we made as researchers, choices inevitably influenced by our own biases, presuppositions and backgrounds (Kapitan, 2023). This includes how we interpreted the behaviours of family members, particularly regarding opposition, autonomy, connection, or emotional expression, aspects that can be expressed and understood differently across cultural contexts.

Case studies

The Beauséjour and Faal families were made up of single migrant mothers living with their children in a densely populated, low-income neighbourhood of Montréal and participated in the home-based version of the program. In addition to being representative of the data, we selected both families because they were facing multiple complex challenges that hampered their daily functioning and because they were single mothers. Moreover, both cases best answered the research question on family dynamics. Analysis of the creative arts therapists' notes and the family members' artworks showed how the *Art et Contes en famille* program might have positively impacted the parent-child connectedness regarding connection, autonomy, and regulation. The following outlines key moments experienced by each family during the program and is not an exhaustive and chronological account of their process, although all research data has been analyzed. We chose to organize the description thematically rather than chronologically to highlight recurring themes or activities. We used pseudonyms to protect the identity of the participants.

Beauséjour family

The Beauséjour family consisted of a mother, who had arrived from

the Caribbean several years before, and three children. They participated in eight workshops facilitated at home by a dramatherapist. Ashley, the mother, was described as having difficulty making eye contact with the workshop facilitator, often looking away and appearing stressed and tired. The eldest son, Kenley, was of primary school age and frequently challenged the mother's instructions. The child also often fell asleep during the sessions. The youngest son, Tayron, also in primary school, was very involved in the creative process, while Maeva, the daughter and youngest child of preschool age, showed a strong dependence on screens, had difficulty regulating her emotions and staying focused on activities. The relationship between mother and children alternated quickly between intense affection and tension, often within mere minutes. Conflicts often emerged between mother and sons when boundaries were set, particularly around phone use. Despite some tensions, there were warm and affectionate moments, especially during art activities, during which Ashley listened to the children, while all four of them had fun together.

Protection or mistrust?

During the second workshop, the mother sought to create a special moment with each of her children. The dramatherapist told a story about a girl who breaks a promise she made to her mother and is captured by monsters who also threaten her brothers. Family members were invited to play the story, and Ashley played the role of the mother. At one moment, she stepped in and saved her children from the monster, embodying a protective figure. After the story, the dramatherapist proposed using playdough to freely create a sculpture. The eldest son told the workshop facilitator that he sculpted his mother as a queen, holding a large candy in her hand, endowed with the power to give life, specifying that this power was represented by an accumulation of clay between her legs. Kenley was affectionate toward his mother, giving her a hug and taking the time to explain his creation to her. On her part, Ashley shaped her eldest son with a balloon, taking time to gently show him her creation. Finally, the youngest son represented his mother with a candy and firmly stated that children must trust their mother, before sharing a knowing smile with her. As for the youngest, Maeva, she was very engaged with her creation, delicately exploring the play dough and paying attention to each piece of clay forming her magical candy. When the workshop was about to end, Kenley, the eldest, shared that his mother had almost died when he was a baby. All the other members were silent and attentive to the story. He remembered that he had been afraid his mother would die at that moment. The dramatherapist took the time to listen, validate his and other family members' emotions and to ensure that everyone felt emotionally safe to continue the workshop.

For the sixth workshop, the eldest son was asleep and did not wake up. The facilitator told a story in which a mother had to leave her children to let them become apprentices, then she invited the family to act out and transform the story. The family changed the story, adding that the mother had to identify her children, who had been transformed into animals. She played along, trying to recognize them one by one by touching their arms, legs, and backs. Everyone laughed, and the children seemed delighted to be recognized. Later, Tayron pointed out the children's emotions in the story, without, however, being able to explain the reason for their emotional states. When the family transformed the story, Ashley played the mother who did not want to leave her children with the "teachers" because she mistrusted them. Instead, she left them with a magician who tricked her by keeping the children, but she was determined to get her children back. Although Tayron presented attention difficulties throughout the story, he demonstrated good self-affirmation, especially in interactions with the teacher characters, firmly stating "no!" As for his sister, she talked and laughed throughout the story, participating as a preschool child could.

The creation part of the workshop was both individual and collective. Each member, inspired by the story, made a sculpture assembling wood pieces and placing them in a collective magical garden. Ashley was very focused during the creative process, and she also gave technical advice to her children. However, the children were not paying attention to her and argued among themselves. Tayron even reacted in the opposite way to his mother's suggestions.

Connecting with each other

To help family members be in the *here* and *now* and relax after hearing the stories, the dramatherapist suggested sensory exploration of various grains, beans, and pebbles to create an image. These creations were not related to the stories told and were first made individually, then collectively (third, fourth and fifth workshops). Initially, it was difficult for Ashley and Tayron to coordinate to create together. During these moments, the mother gave suggestions to her sons such as adding pebbles or making circles. However, the youngest son would initially speak over his mother loudly, also adding elements on top of what his mother had created. He eventually became more receptive to her mother's suggestions. For example, he added a plastic eye to his creation, just as his mother had done. As for Kenley, he gradually began to silently follow his mother's suggestions, while also taking his own initiative. Eventually, the family members managed to create in silence and harmony in a very intuitive and spontaneous way.

It was also during these workshops that the dramatherapist suggested incorporating soothing touch between family members to foster connection, relaxation, and emotional regulation. For example, when Maeva refused to put down her phone, her mother became impatient and the child started to cry. Unable to console her verbally, the mother offered her gentle touch by rubbing her back, which soothed her to the point that she fell asleep. Nevertheless, it was not easy to introduce this way to connect. When Kenley tried to rub her mother's hand, he hurt her by pushing her fingers backward. His mother showed signs of pain but said nothing. Despite these difficulties, the workshop facilitators observed that the mother began to use more instinctively gentle touch to regulate the children's emotions.

Faal family

Originally from a West African country, the single mother Fatoumata lived with her daughter Aminata, her son Omar, and her nephew, who were all of primary school age. Three other adult children lived outside the home. The mother and daughter were the main participants during the home workshops; the son sometimes joined the activities, and occasionally, the eldest daughter, Mariama, when visiting.

During the program, the family experienced several distractions and interruptions. The mother often used her phone or had to temporarily leave. Aminata reassured the dramatherapist that everything was fine and that they could continue. However, this dynamic seemed to create ambivalence in the emotional expression within the family. While Aminata and Omar explored certain emotions through their stories and creative activities, they were having difficulty expressing their emotions in front of their mother, especially when these were considered negative (e.g., sadness, anger, or fear). Although there was occasional tension between the mother and Aminata, the creative moments allowed them to find common ground. Music was also a source of joy and connection for the family. Several key moments demonstrated how the family developed the ability to listen to one another and coexist in a creative space. These activities allowed them to express their emotions, strengthen their bond, and engage in meaningful interactions, despite challenges in communication. At several points during the workshops, the daughter and the mother used creation as a space for reconciliation.

Let's play music

Family members showed mutual listening when they played music together, right from the first workshop. Using maracas, the mother danced in sync with the music, expressing surprise and pleasure through her face. Every time the children played music, the mother followed the proposed rhythm with undulating movements and became very expressive.

Music also brought the parent and children together during the third workshop despite several interruptions. Accordingly, Fatoumata had difficulty concentrating and often followed what the daughter told her to do, without thinking. This also distracted the daughter. Nonetheless, the mother explored the instruments and played a popular song as she encouraged her daughter to dance, clapped for her, and laughed with happiness. When they finished dancing, the mother said that the strength of their family was being united. Despite this connection through music, the daughter turned her back on the mother during the sharing moment at the end of the workshop.

During workshop 7, the mother demonstrated great attentiveness and consideration for Aminata. She made sure to follow the rhythms suggested by her daughter to create music together. During this same workshop, the participants used the electric piano to create music as a family. They were attentive to one another, adjusting their rhythms and volumes, and despite the modest size of the instrument, they shared the space and instrument easily to play together.

Finally, the daughter enthusiastically improvised songs in workshop 8. After saying that the child did not sing but dance, the mother joined in by singing and following Aminata's suggestions. They did not look at each other but were perfectly in sync, improvising songs and laughing together. The facilitator described this moment as magnificent. The daughter named that musical creation *Being Happy*. The workshop facilitator also suggested exploring anger, sadness, fear, and surprise through music, which Aminata happily embraced.

Family love

During workshop 5, the family was invited to use dried grains to create a joint artwork. The beginning of the process was difficult. The daughter told her mother what to do without listening to her mother's ideas, while the mother struggled to accept her daughter's suggestions. The mother undid what the daughter had made, and the latter recreated the initial design. Both seemed uncomfortable with each other's actions. Eventually, they found a way to work together and began accepting one another's ideas. The daughter closely observed what her mother was doing, then drew a heart in the centre of the "heart of the family". Fatoumata suggested "Love" as a title, while Aminata proposed "Heart of the Family", before the two agreed on "Family Love." The mother acknowledged that creating something together had been challenging. The facilitator observed that the mother may still feel a degree of discomfort toward her daughter.

The quarrel

For the last workshop, participants invented a story using the creations made during the program. The daughter invented the story by herself, because her mother arrived late. She began: "Once upon a time, there was a quarrel". Aminata immediately took the mask showing the colours of the flag of their country of origin that her mother had made and her puppet, capable of feeling many emotions. She then brought both characters into a physical confrontation, seeming visibly angry as shown by the puppet's voice and gestures. She then explained the reasons why the argument had broken:

> "Two girls possessed many things and were getting attention, while the others had nothing and also wanted attention. The girls left the wooden house, built by their brother. The girls got into the car built by one of the daughters and drove away from the house. Eventually, everyone returned to live together under the same roof, reconciled, and all received attention". (Aminata).

Aminata seemed appeased and satisfied with her story. However, the girl hesitated to tell it to her mother. She avoided mentioning the characters' anger and the need for attention. Instead, she concentrated on the quarrel itself, and the inequality between the characters.

Discussion: parent-child connectedness in the family creative process

The individual and joint artworks produced during the workshops combined with the dramatherapists' observation notes, provided insight into family dynamics and on how the *Art et Contes en famille* program may have contributed, at least at times, to strengthening parent-child connectedness through better connection, autonomy, and regulation among family members.

Connection

Connection and opposition toward the parent were observed by the dramatherapist, especially for the Beauséjour family. Oppositional behaviour from children toward caregivers is part of the developmental process and can even be encouraged by parents to develop a child's autonomy, but opposition can also disrupt connection within the family, especially when members are not in a close mutual relationship (Kuczynski et al., 2021). Since a closely connected relationship usually involves family members mutually influencing each other (Lezin et al., 2004), the Beauséjour family members may have felt disconnected at the beginning of the program. This is illustrated by Kenley who often was asleep or who challenged his mother's instructions, and Ashley's children not paying attention to her during the workshops.

The dramatherapist also noted that the Beauséjour family experienced initial difficulties in working toward a common goal when creating together, likely complicating connection and the recognition of each other's strengths (Gavron & Mayseless, 2018). Yet the facilitator increasingly observed moments related to a better connection among members. Although Kenley and Tayron did not immediately follow their mother's suggestion during the pebbles creation (workshop 5), the fact that Tayron added a plastic eye to his creation – just as his mother had done – and that Kenley incorporated some of her suggestions into his own could be an indication of the mutual and gradual influence between parent and children, as well as the sons' desire to connect with their mother (Lezin et al., 2004).

Furthermore, the second workshop's story and creation allowed the Beauséjour family to share meaningful moments that may have been beneficial for parent-child connectedness. The mother Ashley appeared to have assumed a central role as protector by saving her children in the story. She may have symbolically embodied a reassuring figure, thereby helping to foster an atmosphere of trust in which the children may have felt they could rely on her (Hordyk et al., 2015). This may even have led Kenley to share his fear of his mother's death, which takes on particular significance in the context of a single-parent family. The role Ashley took in the story could have been a way to express how much she cared for her children but also how she made herself available for them, possibly demonstrating her desire for a more connected relationship (Clark & Ladd, 2000).

The subsequent playdough activity may have further strengthened family connection, as Tayron firmly stated that "children must trust their mother" and Kenley represented her as a queen, a portrayal that could reflect the value he placed on his mother and her protective presence. Ashley seemed to have once again assumed this protective role during workshop 6, when she mentioned that she did not want to leave her children with the "teachers". Meaningful play and creation experiences may indeed promote a sense of safety and encourage the building of a warm and trusting family environment (Parashak, 2011). These moments of closeness, accompanied by affectionate gestures (hugs, smiles, assertive words), could be seen as signs of a strong sense of emotional connectedness among the family members. They are likely to become shared memories later on and contribute to parent-child connectedness (Lezin et al., 2004). However, our findings highlight the fact that establishing a connection is a process that can take time. Indeed, it is possible that Ashley's children may not have truly heeded their mother's advice during workshop 6, even possibly reacting in opposition to her

suggestions, as suggested by Tayron's and Maeva's behaviours. Although the family members may have connected through the laughter generated by the modified story, they may have found themselves confronted with their initial difficulty in working together during art-making. This could, however, be also explained by the fact that the original story of the mother who left her children to become apprentices may have been anxiety-provoking.

Listening – music as a shared space

For the Faal family, moments that could be associated with connection and complicity emerged most clearly during the music-based workshops. When the mother and daughter played music together, they created a shared rhythm. Music seemed to have opened the connection between mother and child, moving them toward increased parent-child connectedness (Jennings, 2010). When the dramatherapist noticed that Fatoumata seemed to be struggling to concentrate and be present for her daughter, music appeared to bring her back to a moment when the mother and the child were perhaps more attentive to one another. Moreover, playing music together may have helped the mother and the child communicating (Nieduziak, 2021) in moments when they may have felt disconnected. Their connection may have been more obvious in moments of shared joy (workshop 4): the mother played a popular song that may have encouraged her daughter to dance, creating a moment suggesting pleasure and complicity, a memory likely to remain significant for both, thereby potentially strengthening parent-child connectedness (Lezin et al., 2004). For the Faal family, music may even have strengthened the connection between family members to the point where mother and daughter improvised a song without even looking at each other (workshop 9). That connection necessitated attentive listening from both members, illustrating how family co-creation may help participants develop the non-verbal communication skills needed to strengthen parent-child connectedness (Arrington, 2001).

When comparing both families, some common points emerge. Moments that could be associated with connection often occurred when the parent and children appeared to be on equal footing and both having an important role to play, thereby emphasizing that high-quality family relationships can rest on recognizing the value of each member (Clark & Ladd, 2000). This was observed in the musical creations of the Beauséjour family, and in the play dough creations the Faal family made. The mothers may have also played a crucial role in maintaining a space where the children could feel safe. This sense of safety may have fostered connection, as the children possibly perceived their mothers as attentive not only to their words but also to their emotions (Arrington, 2001; Parashak, 2011).

Autonomy: learning to listen and make space for one another in collective creation

While participation in the *Art et Contes en famille* program may have provided moments of increased connection between parents and children, it also seemed to have improved autonomy for family members. Although Kenley seemed to gradually take some of his mother's advice during the creation with dried grains, he also came up with ideas of his own. By accepting her son's ideas, Ashley may have recognized his right to make his own choices and possibly allowed him to explore and even assert his identity within the family (Barber & Schluterman, 2008; Miller, 2023).

The dramatherapist also observed a similar process with the Faal family during the same activity. Although the mother and daughter did not initially heed each other's suggestions, the activity appeared to enable Aminata to assert her own preferences by rejecting the changes proposed by her mother and holding on to her original decisions, thereby potentially fostering her autonomy (Barber & Schluterman, 2008). However, this may also have given the mother an opportunity to assert herself, whereas the dramatherapist had noted that she had previously followed Aminata's ideas without question. This is important because both parent and children need to be active participants in the creation of parent-child connectedness (Barber & Schluterman, 2008).

The act of creating together may also have given rise to a negotiation between mother and child, sometimes non-verbal, that may have eventually led both to express their own perspectives and, ultimately, to work in harmony (Nieduziak, 2021). This negotiation may have been possible because both child and parent were possibly able to connect at one point during the creation. Indeed, the dramatherapist noticed that Fatoumata carefully observed what her daughter was doing and eventually made room for her daughter's own expression and choices. Through compromise, they might have been able to ultimately create a joint artwork that satisfied them both. The process of giving a title to this artwork could be a good example of finding a meeting point, "Family Love" being a compromise between Fatoumata's and Aminata's suggestions. This illustrates how important it is to find balance in the ways each family member asserts their autonomy to contribute to healthy relationships and strong parent-child connectedness (Harden, 2014).

However, though the mother and child may have been able to connect while asserting their autonomy during workshop 5, this did not necessarily continue until the end of the program. When she told her story during the last workshop, Aminata kept the character's anger and need for attention to herself, suggesting that she might not have been able to fully assert herself in front of her mother. The fact that the mother was absent during the creation of the story, not dedicating quality time to this shared activity, may explain this and have influenced parent-child connectedness (Clark & Ladd, 2000).

For both families, moments that could be related to increased autonomy were mainly observable during moments of family creation. During these moments, parents and children were attentive and perhaps attuned to each other; this may have enabled family members to connect through reciprocity while also leaving space for the development of autonomy of each member (Barber & Schluterman, 2008). Furthermore, participants were offered the opportunity to make both collective and individual choices in the workshops, contributing potentially to their autonomy (Ryzin & Fosco, 2015). In turn, by allowing their children the freedom to express their creativity while supporting their abilities and providing assistance when needed, parents may also have contributed to their regulation.

Regulation: exploring emotions through movement and storytelling

Throughout the *Art et Contes en famille* program, parents from both families appeared to engage, although differently and on different levels, in behaviours aiming at managing space and regulating their children. In the Beauséjour family, the workshop facilitator believed that all members seemed to have difficulty adequately expressing and regulating their own emotions. At various points during the workshops, rapid shifts were observed in the emotions displayed toward one another, moving from what appeared to be joy to tension and conflict. This may have occurred particularly when the mother was attempting to establish a structure, that is when she was trying to regulate her children (Lezin et al., 2004). Furthermore, the fact that Ashley did not stop her eldest son from painfully bending her fingers backward suggests that she may have also struggled to regulate her own emotions, which, in turn, could have affected her children's ability to do so (Lanjekar et al., 2022). This could also be observed when Tayron shouted angrily, "No!" every time a teacher appeared in the story or when he was unable to explain the characters' emotions (workshop 6), or when Maeva was unconsolable for having to put down her phone (workshop 5).

Nonetheless, participation in the *Art et Contes en famille* program seemed to have offered a tool for the Beauséjour family members to better regulate their emotions, especially through soothing touch. The fact that they eventually engaged in soothing touch with one another, and that Ashley appeared to use soothing touch intentionally to help both herself and her children regulate their emotions, could indicate that she had taken action to support her children's emotional safety, and

thereby ensure better regulation (Lezin et al., 2004). This mutual regulation might have been possible because it was first combined with family co-creation through sensory exploration, which may have helped participants to express their emotions more adequately while possibly connecting with each other's emotions (Gavron & Mayseless, 2018; Lezin et al., 2004).

For the Faal family, attempts at regulation were perhaps mostly achieved through play and creative activities, especially for the daughter Aminata. Even though Fatoumata and her daughter eventually seemed able to create together in relative harmony and pleasure, it was perhaps when she was playing and creating by herself that Aminata was best able to explore and express various emotions (e.g., workshop 8). Furthermore, as the daughter recounted, the puppet Bella Crystal was also capable of experiencing a wide range of emotions. This suggests that the art therapy space may have provided a safe container for Aminata to explore different emotions (Proulx, 2002). However, regulation from the part of the parent involves ensuring children's emotional safety (Lezin et al., 2004). The fact that the child avoided mentioning the character's anger and need for attention when recounting the story of the Quarrel to her parent could indicate that the mother did not quite succeed in making her child feel safe enough to express difficult emotions in her presence.

For both families, the program may have offered a safe framework through which children may have been more receptive to their parent's attempt to set boundaries (Proulx, 2002). Feeling safe enough, they were perhaps able to explore emotions but also ways to regulate them. As the parents seemed better able to set boundaries, at least at times, parents and children were conceivably able to achieve mutual regulation, particularly during moments of family creation (Gavron & Mayseless, 2018). In these moments, Beauséjour and Faal family members perhaps mutually adjusted to one another, allowing for mutual understanding and maintaining harmony. Through individual and joint artistic creation, it may have been possible to gain insights into parent-child connectedness, especially considering the themes they explored such as protection, love, adversity (Gavron & Mayseless, 2018; Parashak, 2011).

Strengths and limitations

Using case studies allowed for a deeper understanding of the processes of the Beauséjour and the Faal families (Yin, 2017). However, the findings presented in this article represent only a fraction of what single-parent families from immigrant background can experience, highlighting the need to avoid generalization. The development of parent-child connectedness and its overarching dimensions of connection, autonomy and regulation is unique to each family as it depends on emotional exchanges with others (Barber & Schluterman, 2008). To have a more comprehensive portrait of how participation in the *Art et Contes en famille* program may play a role in the development of parent-child connectedness, it would be necessary to replicate the study with a greater number of families and to centre specifically on parent-child connectedness in the data collection. Indeed, the present study aimed at examining the effects of the program on parental stress and family dynamics, but without a specific focus on connectedness.

Furthermore, rendering the complexity of a group process is not an easy task, as this includes both a collective family process and individual processes for each member. The limited scope of this article only allowed us to highlight certain moments of each family process, thus rendering a portrait that may look incomplete. Nonetheless, because the article focused on two families whose experience in terms of parent-child connectedness shared points of convergence and divergence, this allowed for a better understanding of the phenomenon (Yin, 2017).

Lastly, despite measures taken to ensure that the interpretation of data was the closest possible to both families' experiences, we cannot guarantee that the content that we share in this article does indeed represent their experience accurately. In that sense, it could have been interesting to include interviews with participating families to get their insights on their own experiences. We did, however, triangulate sources and data collection tools to multiply the points of view and strengthen the credibility of our interpretation (Kapitan, 2023).

Conclusion

As single-parent families from immigrant background, the Beauséjour and Faal families faced multiple challenges that could have been conducive to the development of family violence following the pandemic of COVID-19 (Humphreys et al., 2020; Patwardhan et al., 2017). Although the findings of this research do not allow us to conclude that participation in the *Art et Contes en famille* program prevented the onset of family violence in both families, they do highlight the potential contribution of the intervention on the decrease of risk factors, but mostly on the increase of protection factors, such as parent-child connectedness. By positively influencing how the family members connected to each other, but also how each member gained better autonomy and regulation skills, the program may have strengthened parent-child connectedness, which is one of the most protective factors when facing adversity (Ayika et al., 2018; Ryzin & Fosco, 2015). Despite the limited scope of this study, home-based community art therapy thus appears to be a resource that could help families from immigrant background to reconnect and strengthen family relationships by using play and art creation. Community organizations, schools, but also health and social services should therefore consider integrating this type of intervention into their frontline services and broader programs focused on family mental health and well-being. Organizations providing settlement services could particularly benefit from incorporating this type of intervention into their service offerings. Such a measure would help prevent the exacerbation of difficulties in both parents and children, while improving access to mental health support services for families who might not otherwise seek help.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Maïté Simard: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Katia Lemieux:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Formal analysis, Data curation. **Janie Pomerleau:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Project administration, Funding acquisition. **Caroline Beauregard:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Supervision, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

Ethics declaration

Written informed consent to take part in the study and to publish the article has been obtained from all participants or their legal representatives. The privacy rights of participants have been observed.

This study was performed in compliance with relevant laws, regulatory frameworks and guidelines where the research took place. This study was approved by the Comité d'éthique de la recherche de l'Université du Québec en Abitibi-Témiscamingue. (Approval No. 2022–04)

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Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare the following financial interests/personal relationships which may be considered as potential competing interests:

Janie Pomerleau reports financial support was provided by Public Health Agency of Canada. Janie Pomerleau reports a relationship with Parc-Extension Youth Organization that includes: employment. If there are other authors, they declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

The data that has been used is confidential.

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